

Catholic Exorcism

History, Discipline, and Pastoral Practice

Scripture, ritual development, canon law,
discernment, and care of afflicted persons

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1 The first rule is about the person

Governing thesis

Catholic exorcism did not develop as a secret technology for specialists. It developed where several obligations meet: proclaim Christ's victory, distinguish kinds of prayer and authority, test historical claims against their witnesses, separate spiritual judgment from medical diagnosis, and protect a suffering person from credulity as well as disbelief.

Confidentiality is not theatrical mystique. A person seeking help is not evidence for someone else's argument, material for a recording, or a character in a horror story. Curiosity becomes harmful when it invites imitation, fixes attention on lurid details, rewards confident amateurs, or turns illness and trauma into spectacle. A reader who fears immediate danger should use emergency services; one who is ill should continue medical and mental-health care; one seeking the Church's pastoral help should begin with a parish or diocese, not an internet ritual.

That boundary directs attention away from spectacle and toward the historical question: how did Christians move from biblical narratives and diverse early practices to rites whose use, minister, and interpretation the Church increasingly disciplined? The answer is not a single unbroken ceremony. Apologetic claims, baptismal preparation, clerical offices, prayers over afflicted persons, ritual books, canon law, and modern safeguarding overlap, but they are not interchangeable.

1.1 Continuity without identity

The governing argument of this study is continuity without identity. The New Testament's proclamation of Christ's authority is indispensable to the Christian history, but a Gospel narrative is not a later ritual book. An ancient apologist's public challenge is evidence for the claim he made, not a statistical report. An exorcism connected with Christian initiation is not on that account a judgment that a candidate is possessed. The presence of exorcists in a clergy list does not reveal all their duties, and a medieval formula does not establish how often it was used. The Roman book of 1614 consolidated and disciplined an inherited practice; it did not create the whole Christian history that preceded it. Modern canon law, ritual revision, clinical consultation, and safeguarding likewise do not erase the past. They identify responsibilities that historical romanticism can obscure.

This distinction permits two errors to be refused together. A history can flatten every witness into one changeless ceremony and thereby make later rules appear already complete in the earliest texts. Or it can treat every difference as a rupture and miss the recurring Christian convictions that give the history coherence: Christ's victory, prayer in and through the Church, the creaturely limits of evil, the need for discernment, and the dignity of the afflicted person. Neither an unbroken-script story nor a succession of unrelated curiosities can account for the evidence.

The sources also differ in what they are competent to establish. Scripture, ancient literature, catechesis, liturgical books, conciliar and canonical acts, school theology, official pastoral guidance, clinical classification, and safeguarding records answer different questions. They can illuminate one another, but one cannot silently do another's work. A legal text can identify a minister and permission without diagnosing a person. A clinical classification can organize a differential assessment without deciding a theological cause. A narrative can show how an event was understood without becoming a neutral medical file. Much of the apparent confusion surrounding exorcism begins when these authorities are asked to say more than they say.

1.2 The subject and the limits of the inquiry

The subject is therefore larger than the solemn rite and narrower than every claim ever made about spirits. It includes the biblical and theological horizon within which Christians spoke about liberation from evil; the initiatory, ministerial, and ritual settings in which exorcistic language was used; the consolidation and revision of Roman books; the law governing the Latin Church; and the pastoral disciplines that protect persons today. It does not require a catalog of sensational cases, a taxonomy of alleged signs, or speculation about names and ranks that the governing authorities do not teach as dogma.

Some evidence remains unavailable, disputed, or too weak for the claim readers might expect it to bear. That absence is part of the history. It is better to identify an uncontrolled church order, an uncollated medieval formulary, a

territorial legal boundary, or a case without a sufficient documentary chain than to bridge the gap with a familiar story. The account that follows marks those ceilings where they arise and reserves its fuller statement of corpus, method, jurisdiction, and currentness for the terminal scope appendix.

Three distinctions matter from the outset. Ordinary Christian prayer for deliverance from evil is not the reserved major rite. Minor exorcisms belong especially to authorized Christian initiation and do not declare a catechumen possessed. Major exorcism is an ecclesial liturgical sacramental, ordinarily celebrated with strict confidentiality, whose lawful use in the Latin Church requires the authority identified by canon 1172; it is neither a sacrament nor medical treatment.

Those distinctions protect ordinary Christian life from being absorbed into an extraordinary category. Temptation is not possession. Sin is not a clinical syndrome. Illness is not evidence of spiritual guilt. Prayer for deliverance does not create permission to perform a reserved rite. Nor does recognizing natural causes imply that Christian teaching has nothing to say about evil, suffering, freedom, or hope. The responsible account keeps theological, juridical, historical, and clinical judgments distinct while allowing each to contribute within its proper competence.

A safety boundary

This is historical, theological, and canonical study, not diagnosis or a field manual. It does not provide the prayers, alleged signs, interview prompts, commands, names, or sequence of a major exorcism. No reader is authorized by reading it. Nothing here warrants stopping medication or therapy, confronting a distressed person, testing a supernatural hypothesis, or attempting self-exorcism.

2 Before the Christian Rite: Ancient Contexts

Christian exorcism did not arise in a world without discourse about hostile spiritual agency. The witnesses below supply context, not a genealogy. Similar acts can rest on incompatible accounts of God, spirits, illness, ritual efficacy, and authorized ministry; resemblance does not prove literary dependence.

2.1 Israel's Scriptures: affliction without a ritual manual

The Hebrew Bible resists being flattened into a handbook. The harmful spirit in 1 Samuel 16 belongs to a narrative of kingship and judgment; David's music gives Saul relief, but the narrator supplies neither adjuration nor ministerial office. Tobit 6–8 joins Raphael's direction, Tobias and Sarah's prayer, marriage, material means, healing, and angelic action under providence. Its Greek recensions and Latin reception do not always arrange or phrase the episode identically. The history must therefore identify its textual form. Neither narrative is a primitive Roman rite or a general authorization to imitate its material action.

The contrast between the two narratives is as important as their shared language of hostile agency. In the tracked Douay–Rheims/Challoner reception of 1 Samuel—numbered 1 Kings—Saul's affliction belongs to the transfer of kingship: the Spirit of the Lord departs from Saul, the harmful spirit troubles him, his servants propose music, and David's playing brings refreshment. Saul does not request an exorcist, David does not interrogate or adjure the spirit, and no repeatable words are given. The episode can illuminate later Christian reflection on affliction, providence, and relief, but it cannot establish an Israelite exorcistic office from details the narrator never supplies.

Tobit is more explicitly ritualized but no less resistant to extraction from its plot. Raphael's instruction concerning the fish, Tobias and Sarah's entry into marriage, their prayer for mercy, the burning of the fish's heart and liver, the demon's flight, and Raphael's binding action form one narrated sequence. Agency is distributed: the angel instructs and acts, the couple prays, material means are used, and deliverance belongs to a providential story that also includes healing Tobit's blindness. Selecting the smoke while discarding prayer, marriage, angelic commission, and the book's textual history would turn narrative into a technique. The present exact control is the Catholic English reception text; until the materially different Greek recensions are collated, this account cannot support a claim about the earliest recoverable wording or sequence.

2.2 Second Temple plurality

In R. H. Charles's English translation, *Jubilees* 10.1–11 depicts destructive spirits afflicting Noah's descendants and Noah petitioning God. After Mastema asks that some remain under him, God permits one tenth to remain and consigns nine tenths to condemnation. This is a literary episode in rewritten Scripture, not evidence of one standard Jewish ceremony; Charles's translation is not an original-language control.

Josephus presents himself as having seen Eleazar perform before Vespasian and a military audience. The account says that God gave Solomon skill against demons; Eleazar uses a ring containing a root, mentions Solomon while reciting incantations attributed to him, and commands the departing demon to overturn a water-filled cup or basin. The locus is *Antiquities* 8.45–49 in modern Niese numbering and VIII.2.5 in Whiston's division. It establishes Josephus's late-first-century literary testimony and Solomonic framing, not the mechanism, actual Solomonic authorship, or an unbroken route into the Christian rite.

Together these witnesses show why “the Jewish background” is too singular: genre, means, agent, theology, and purpose differ.

2.3 Petition, attributed technique, and narrative authority

The difference can be stated without forcing either witness into a later Christian taxonomy. In *Jubilees*, the decisive appeal is Noah's petition to God. Mastema's counter-request and God's disposition of the spirits explain the literary world's continuing affliction; they do not present Noah as the operator of a transferable ceremony. Josephus, by contrast, describes a performance attributed to Solomonic wisdom: a named human practitioner, a ring and root, recited incantations, and a visible test before a military audience. One text explains hostile spirits within rewritten sacred history; the other offers an antiquarian and apologetic report of inherited Jewish wisdom.

That contrast prevents two opposite errors. It is too strong to say that late-first-century Jewish literature knew no practices directed against demons, because Josephus expressly reports one. It is equally too strong to call Josephus's Eleazar the representative Jewish exorcist or to make his performance the missing link between Tobit and the Gospels. The checked witnesses establish plurality. A genealogy would require common wording, a traceable chain of transmission, or an ancient statement of dependence that they do not provide.

2.4 The limits of the present ancient corpus

The present corpus is deliberately small. It does not yet use the Genesis Apocryphon, Qumran apotropaic compositions, or an original-language text of *Jubilees* as publication evidence. Nor does the Whiston control replace inspection of Josephus's Greek. Those absences matter more in an expanded history than another list of loosely similar rites would. Until exact edition-identified witnesses are bound, the defensible result is not a census of Second Temple practice but a demonstration that two checked sources already resist the singular phrase “the Jewish rite of exorcism.”

2.5 Comparison without a borrowed-rite thesis

The draft does not convert a broad list of Mesopotamian, Egyptian, Greek, or Roman practices into a supposed background rite. Such comparison requires genre-, date-, and edition-specific witnesses. Without a shared formula, traceable route, or explicit ancient claim of borrowing, resemblance remains context rather than descent.

3 The Biblical Witness

The Gospels distinguish demonic affliction from disease without supplying a modern diagnostic chart. Matthew 4:24 lists the demonized, epileptics, and paralytics separately; Mark 1:32–34 can place the sick and demonized side by side. Conversely, symptoms in individual narratives overlap conditions that now receive medical explanations. Narrative classification is theological testimony, not permission to diagnose a contemporary person from resemblance.

3.1 Words, agents, and narrative judgment

The Greek vocabulary does not itself settle the phenomenon behind a scene. The Gospels use forms of the designation commonly rendered “unclean spirit” and forms of *daimonizomai*, commonly rendered by “possessed” or, more transparently, “demonized.” Neither expression is a clinical category, and neither tells a modern reader how to infer an invisible cause from symptoms. The narratives make theological judgments through plot, speech, command, restoration, and the evangelist’s framing. “Demonized” remains a translation choice rather than a diagnosis.

3.2 Vocabulary inside narrative

The same expression can do different work in different scenes. An “unclean spirit” speaks in the synagogue at Mark 1, is associated with a man’s destructive isolation in Mark 5, and departs from many persons in the mission summary of Acts 8. Forms commonly rendered “demonized” identify persons within Gospel narration, while Acts 19 calls certain itinerants “exorcists.” That last noun identifies the actors who attempt an adjuration; it does not retroactively turn every Gospel healing or command into an example of their trade.

Verbs likewise require their sentences. Jesus rebukes and commands; the evangelists speak of spirits departing or being cast out; Paul commands in the name of Jesus Christ; the sons of Sceva attempt to adjure by the Jesus whom Paul preaches. A concordance can locate those expressions, but it cannot erase the difference between Christ’s own authority, delegated mission, prayerful dependence, and attempted appropriation. The present Greek control is one identified Byzantine textform. It supports these local observations, not a claim that later ecclesiastical terminology was already a fixed New Testament system.

3.3 Mark: authority, conflict, restoration

Mark gives the most sustained architecture. At 1:21–28 Jesus commands the unclean spirit without apparatus; the crowd asks what this authority means. Mark 3:22–27 interprets the works through the image of binding the strong man, placing particular expulsions within the invasion of Satan’s domain. Mark 5:1–20 joins command, contested naming, destructive power, restoration, and mission. The man’s restored condition—clothed, composed, and sent back to his own people—is narratively more important than the spirits’ attempted control of the exchange. Their speech belongs to the conflict scene; it is not a deposit of reliable demonological information.

The sequence also disciplines later fascination with names. Jesus asks, the reply “Legion” is given, and the spirits plead about their destination. Mark does not present that exchange as a lesson requiring later ministers to obtain hidden names. Its narrative movement is away from the spirits’ self- presentation and toward the restored man: his neighbors see him, fear, ask Jesus to leave, and then receive the man’s testimony about what the Lord has done. Whatever historical questions surround the scene, Mark’s literary emphasis is authority, restoration, and witness rather than information gathered from hostile speakers.

Mark 9:14–29 places a suffering child, an anguished father, failed disciples, and Jesus’ command within a lesson on dependent faith and prayer. Verse 29 is also a textual and reception-history hinge. The tracked Robinson–Pierpont Byzantine textform includes “and fasting” and its inline divergence note reports that the Nestle–Aland text omits those words. The tracked Douay–Rheims/Challoner witness also reads “prayer and fasting,” at Mark 9:28 in its numbering. The repository does not yet bind a separately identified eclectic edition or a full critical apparatus. These controls establish the existence of the variant, not its manuscript history or relative weight; an argument resting on fasting must therefore name its textual tradition.

The variant is historically important because later ascetical and ritual reception can quote “prayer and fasting” as a unit. It does not change the scene into a procedural checklist. The disciples’ private question receives an answer about dependence rather than a longer command, a material object, or a catalog of signs. The present witnesses establish a Byzantine and Catholic English reception of fasting; they do not authorize describing that wording as textually uncontested.

3.4 Matthew and Luke: the kingdom has arrived

Matthew organizes the controversy around the kingdom and the Spirit of God (Mt 12:22–32); Luke says “the finger of God” (Lk 11:20), echoing Exodus and making expulsion a sign that God’s reign has arrived. Luke 10:17–20 subordinates successful ministry to the disciples’ names being written in heaven. The return of the unclean spirit in Matthew 12:43–45 and Luke 11:24–26 is a warning against an emptied life, not a technical case-history protocol.

The Matthew–Luke variation also locates the controversy within each Evangelist’s scriptural rhetoric. Matthew names the Spirit of God; Luke names the finger of God. Both sayings answer the accusation that Jesus acts by Beelzebul, and both turn the accusation back through the divided-house and strong-man arguments. The point is not merely that an afflicted person has improved. The expulsions signify the stronger one’s victory and the arrival of God’s reign. An eventual history of rites must preserve that canonical claim without pretending that the Gospels thereby prescribe the Church’s later minister, permissions, or formulary.

Luke 10 adds a second restraint. The disciples rejoice that spirits are subject to them in Jesus’ name, but Jesus redirects joy toward their names being written in heaven. Authority is real within the narrative, yet success over spirits is not made the disciples’ identity or spiritual status. That redirection stands in tension with later cultures of celebrity, expertise, or curiosity built around extraordinary ministry.

3.5 Acts: mission is not a manipulable name

Acts preserves both continuity and boundary. Philip’s mission includes unclean spirits departing (Acts 8:7); Paul commands the divining spirit “in the name of Jesus Christ” (16:18). Acts 19:11–20 then contrasts apostolic mission with the sons of Sceva’s attempted use of Jesus’ name as a transferable technique. The failure is not evidence that a longer formula was needed. It marks the difference between belonging to Christ’s mission and manipulating a powerful name.

The three Acts settings should not be collapsed. Philip’s preaching and the departure of unclean spirits belong to a city receiving the Gospel. Paul’s command in Acts 16 interrupts the repeated speech of a divining spirit in a mission conflict. At Ephesus, extraordinary deeds associated with Paul’s ministry are set beside itinerant exorcists who try to use the preached name secondhand; the episode ends not with a better incantation but with fear, confession, and the destruction of costly magical books. The narrative judges the means by their relation to apostolic mission and conversion.

Acts 19 is therefore evidence both of continuity and discontinuity with the ancient context. It knows actors identified as exorcists and an adjutory use of a powerful name, features that make comparison with Josephus intelligible. But Luke’s arrangement refuses to treat every use of Jesus’ name as Christian ministry. Similar outward speech does not establish common authority, theology, or efficacy.

3.6 What the canon does and does not give

The canonical pattern is consequently christological and ecclesial before it is procedural. Jesus’ authority, the advent of God’s kingdom, prayer, mission, conversion, and freedom from fear hold the narratives together. Scripture supports the Church’s confession that Christ defeats evil; it does not itself specify the later ministerial reservation, diagnostic process, or Roman ritual.

The same boundary is moral as well as historical. Narrative details describe particular persons within particular theological plots. They are not a list by which a reader may classify another person’s illness, disability, trauma, speech, or behavior. Several Gospel summaries distinguish illnesses from hostile spirits even while placing both beneath Christ’s authority. Modern readers should not collapse categories the evangelists kept distinct, still less translate either one directly into a retrospective clinical diagnosis.

This section does not settle later theological questions about natural and preternatural causation. Its narrower conclusion is that the Gospel narratives warrant neither dismissal of the evangelists’ theological claims nor a contemporary diagnosis by analogy.

4 Patristic Reception: Apology, Initiation, and Office

The early Christian witnesses do not describe one undifferentiated practice. They place exorcistic language in at least three settings that must remain separate: apologetic claims about extraordinary affliction, the preparation of candidates for Baptism, and lists or rules concerning ecclesiastical ministers. A word shared across those settings does not establish that the same act, subject, minister, or degree of authority is meant.

4.1 Apologetic claims are claims, not case files

Justin's *Second Apology* 6 appeals to what he presents as observable Christian expulsion of demons in Jesus Christ's name and contrasts it with other exorcists, incantations, and drugs. The exact checked witness is the Dods-Reith English translation in the 1887 *Ante-Nicene Fathers* OCR, not an original-language control. Justin's partisan argument attests what he claimed; it is not a neutral transcript, a success statistic, or authorization for later readers to seek spectacle.

Tertullian, *Apology* 23, frames a proposed public test in forensic rhetoric. Origen, *Against Celsus* 1.6 and 7.4, contrasts prayer and simple Christian adjuration with magical apparatus; 1.25 instead advances a broader theory about the efficacy of names. These exact English witnesses control the authors' arguments, not actual tribunal proceedings, outcomes, or one common theory of ritual speech.

Read together, these witnesses show that second- and third-century Christian authors could make public arguments about deliverance in Christ's name. They do not yield a dossier of named persons, dates, diagnoses, independently observed outcomes, or rates of success. Nor do they supply one stable formula. Justin offers an appeal to Christian experience; Tertullian stages a forensic challenge; Origen answers a learned critic and distinguishes Christian prayer from arts he rejects. Their genres and argumentative opponents help explain what each passage can establish.

The difference inside Origen's own argument is especially important. *Against Celsus* 1.6 and 7.4 support the limited contrast between simple Christian invocation or adjuration and magical apparatus. Section 1.25 belongs to a broader account of the efficacy of names. Combining all three into a single supposed patristic technique would erase a distinction present in the checked work itself.

These passages therefore establish a history of Christian claims before they establish a history of institutions. They do not by themselves show how common a practice was, corroborate a reported event, establish a liturgical formulary, or identify a permanent office.

4.2 Jerusalem: exorcism within initiation

Procatechesis 9 addresses candidates undergoing exorcisms and uses refining imagery. Its immediate setting is preparation for initiation, not a retrospective account of an extraordinary case. The first Jerusalem *Mystagogical Catechesis*, 1.4–9, recalls the candidate's westward renunciation of Satan and eastward turn toward Christ. The sequence joins renunciation and confession to incorporation into Christian life.

This evidence does not permit the categories to be reversed. It does not show that every candidate was judged to be extraordinarily possessed, and it does not make the initiatory acts an early edition of the later Roman rite for the possessed. It witnesses a local catechetical and liturgical setting in which deliverance language helped interpret the passage from an old allegiance to a new one.

The latter work's authorship remains disputed. The exact Gifford English witness therefore controls a Jerusalem sequence rather than unqualified personal authorship by Cyril. Neither the transmitted attribution nor the clarity of the sequence makes it a universal fourth-century rite. Comparison with other regions requires their own edition-identified witnesses.

4.3 A Roman list is not a complete job description

Eusebius's quotation of Cornelius's Roman clergy list gives fifty-two as one combined total for exorcists, readers, and door-keepers (*Church History* 6.43.11). It supplies no separate number of exorcists and no description of their

ordinary duties. It nevertheless provides a bounded institutional witness: a mid-third-century Roman bishop could name exorcists among the church’s personnel.

That narrow finding cannot support several common expansions. The passage does not say that fifty-two exorcists served at Rome; it combines three groups. It does not identify the grade with every later act called exorcism, or prove that its members performed the later major rite over the possessed. It also does not show that every church used the same arrangement. Office, ordination, delegated action, baptismal preparation, and extraordinary affliction remain separate historical questions.

4.4 Patristic breadth without a vote count

The Fathers do not supply one treatise entitled “the Catholic doctrine of exorcism.” Their evidence is distributed among rules of faith, apologetic challenges, baptismal catecheses, biblical homilies, church orders, letters, and narratives. Irenaeus is important first as a control on method. His *Against Heresies* 1.10 describes one received faith confessed throughout churches of different languages. That passage does not enumerate an exorcistic rite. It prevents a local practice or a later technical vocabulary from being promoted into the content of the rule of faith merely because a Father mentions demons elsewhere.

A reception sweep asks five different questions of every witness: what biblical text is being read; what claim about Christ or creation is being made; whether the setting is initiation or extraordinary affliction; who is represented as acting; and what authority the genre can bear. Justin answers chiefly the apologetic question; Tertullian and Origen show that even apologetic arguments do not all take the same form; the Jerusalem witnesses answer an initiatory question; and Eusebius answers one institutional question. None supplies all five.

The surviving record is also uneven. Greek and Latin corpora are more readily available in old printed translations than many Syriac, Coptic, Armenian, and Ethiopic church-order witnesses. Silence in the presently checked corpus cannot be advertised as patristic silence. A negative claim is warranted only when it names the exact artifact or bounded corpus searched, the terms and languages used, and the limitations of OCR or translation.

The exact checked patristic passages do not preserve an apostolic script. Later ritual organization cannot be inferred from verbal resemblance alone. Two prominent leads remain outside the account’s positive evidence. Laodicea 26 may bear on the discipline of persons acting in churches or private houses, but it is not used here until an exact consulted passage is registered and its local or conciliar scope is controlled. The church-order complex conventionally called the *Apostolic Tradition* contains important initiatory material in reconstructions numbered 20–21, but its unity, authorship, date, Roman provenance, versional basis, and chapter equivalences remain disputed. A searchable older reconstruction cannot stand silently for a securely recoverable work of Hippolytus or for a universal Roman rite around 215.

Those exclusions are evidence disciplines, not claims that the texts are irrelevant. They prevent a lead from filling the very gap under investigation. Until the consulted textual forms and specialist controls are exact, neither witness supplies a step in a continuous line from the apostles to the 1614 Roman Ritual.

Witness family	Secure contribution	Evidentiary ceiling
Justin, Tertullian, and Origen	Distinct public arguments about Christian deliverance in Christ’s name	Literary claims in identified English witnesses, not measured outcomes or one formulary
Jerusalem catecheses	Exorcism and renunciation situated in baptismal preparation	A qualified Jerusalem sequence, not universal practice or a major-exorcism case
Cornelius through Eusebius	Exorcists named among third-century Roman church personnel	One combined count and no complete duty description
Irenaeus’s rule of faith	A methodological boundary between received faith and local practice	No exorcistic formulary or practice inventory
Laodicea and church-order leads	Questions for later disciplinary and initiatory comparison	No positive claim here until exact textual and scope controls are registered

5 Late-Antique Offices and Medieval Plurality

5.1 An office does not yet make a uniform practice

By the middle of the third century, the Roman church could count exorcists among its ministers: Eusebius preserves Cornelius of Rome's list of clergy, including fifty-two exorcists, readers, and doorkeepers (*Ecclesiastical History* 6.43). The number witnesses an identifiable ecclesial category at Rome, not fifty-two specialists in the later solemn rite. The list does not disclose how those grouped ministers divided their duties. Nor does a Roman list establish the same arrangement in every church.

Other local disciplinary witnesses remain part of the research horizon, but this edition does not use them positively because no exact retained and bound text controls their wording. They therefore cannot establish a universal ordination form, the frequency of extraordinary cases, or identity between an early office and the priest who would later perform a major exorcism.

A representative medieval ordinal has not yet been acquired and collated for this study. It therefore makes no positive claim from an ordination formulary about delivery of a book, the duties of officeholders, medieval career paths, ordinary practice, or a transfer of extraordinary intervention to priests. This is not a claim that the office lacked a formulary. It is a limit on what this edition can say about the wording, transmission, and use of any such formulary without an edition-identified text and a selected manuscript witness.

5.2 From scrutinies to ritual-book controls

In H. A. Wilson's 1894 edition of the book conventionally called the *Gelasian Sacramentary*, the heading *Exorcismi super electos* appears within a continuous sequence of scrutinies and other rites for the elect (pp. 45–50). The prayers on pp. 48–49 repeatedly order the action to baptismal grace. This exact edition witness establishes the placement of exorcistic formulas within baptismal preparation. It does not by itself attribute the extant compilation to Gelasius I, establish one pristine Roman use, collate the printed text against the manuscript, or date each textual stratum.

The Vogel–Elze critical edition supplies bibliographic control for the tenth-century compilation conventionally called the *Pontificale Romano-Germanicum*. The present source record does not yet contain an exact artifact, identified ordines and pages, or manuscript-to-edition collation. The edition supplies only the bibliographic identity of a compilation assigned to the tenth century. Its precise contents, internal juxtapositions, routes of circulation, and evidence for actual local use require further collation. Neither a rubric nor the survival of a formula would by itself establish frequency of use or incidence of possession.

These two controlled points belong to different histories. Wilson's printed sequence concerns people preparing for Baptism. The PRG is presently only the identity of a later compilation whose relevant contents have not been checked for this publication. Similar vocabulary across those settings cannot bridge the evidentiary gap. A history of a formula asks where text appears and how it changes; a history of a rite also asks who acts, over whom, in what setting, and under what authority; a history of practice requires evidence that a community actually used it. This edition has the first kind of evidence for Wilson's bounded baptismal sequence, not the latter two kinds for medieval extraordinary exorcism.

5.3 Sacramental theology and differentiated effects

Thomas Aquinas treats the preparations accompanying Baptism in *Summa theologiae* III, question 71. He asks what effect exorcistic preparations have and distinguishes their removal of impediments from Baptism's gift of grace and remission. His account is a scholastic explanation of received baptismal rites, not an ethnographic description of every thirteenth-century parish and not a manual for extraordinary exorcism.

The same distinction prevents anachronism about the minor order. Aquinas locates exorcists among ministers assisting the priest (III, q. 71, a. 4); he does not thereby prove that every holder regularly confronted alleged possession. Office, ordination, delegated exercise, baptismal preparation, and extraordinary care remain separate historical questions.

Medieval sources use exorcistic language in more than one ritual setting. Until representative rites are identified by book, locus, recipient, and minister, this study does not treat those settings as one rite or infer practice from shared

vocabulary.

5.4 Continuity without a single medieval script

The checked witnesses permit a limited continuity claim. A named Roman ministerial category is visible in Cornelius's third-century list; a late-antique sacramentary tradition, as printed by Wilson, places exorcistic prayers in preparation for Baptism; and Aquinas later explains the effects of such baptismal preparations while locating the exorcist in an assisting ministerial order. The witnesses are separated by centuries and genres. They show that office, initiatory prayer, and scholastic explanation all belong to the Western history, but they do not show that one text, ministerial duty, or ceremonial route passed unchanged through that interval.

That distinction also keeps two recipients apart. A catechumen undergoing preparation for Baptism is not thereby a baptized person presented for an extraordinary intervention. Conversely, later language about an afflicted or possessed Christian cannot be read back into every initiatory exorcism. The history needs exact book-level controls before it can describe when and where those ritual paths were placed beside one another, separated, or recombined.

The same caution applies to authority. Cornelius's list establishes an ecclesial category at one place and date; Wilson establishes the arrangement of one printed edition; Aquinas supplies a theological account. None of those witnesses independently establishes a universal medieval reservation, a local delegation rule, or the practical relation between minor-order exorcists and priests. Present Latin law and the modern major rite therefore cannot be used to fill the medieval silence.

5.5 Narrative and adjacent-history limits

Narrative sources are not neutral medical files. Without an exact narrative witness and a genre control, this study does not infer a subject's clinical condition, the cause of an episode, or the frequency of possession from a saint's life, miracle collection, chronicle, sermon, or exemplum. Surviving medieval sources use multiple, non-equivalent categories, but this study has not yet established their distribution across medical, penitential, pastoral, legal, and hagiographic corpora. Modern diagnoses cannot responsibly be assigned retrospectively to persons known only through stylized narratives.

Liturgical, theological, penitential, canonical, legal, and hagiographic records answer different questions. None may silently substitute for another. This study has not yet acquired the exact cross-genre witnesses needed to describe interactions among exorcism, magic, heresy, medicine, and learned demonology across the medieval period. It therefore makes no claim here about their chronology, prevalence, or institutional relationship.

The exact controls retained here establish a baptismal formulary in Wilson's Gelasian edition and Aquinas's theological distinction between baptismal preparations and the sacrament's effect. The PRG remains only a bibliographic coordinate. These controls do not establish one unchanged medieval script or a uniform practice. The *Rituale Romanum* of 1614 belongs to a later, separately controlled stage of the history.

6 Early Modern Consolidation and the Roman Ritual of 1614

6.1 A Roman book did not create a Roman monopoly

The *Rituale Romanum* issued under Paul V in 1614 belongs to the post-Tridentine effort to provide dependable Roman books where local manuals remained diverse. Its appearance is therefore a history of consolidation, not an origin story for Christian exorcism. Baptismal exorcisms, prayers over the afflicted, episcopal regulation, and regional formularies all preceded it. Nor did publication instantly abolish diocesan custom: the title page presents a Roman norm commended to pastors, while reception depended on local authority, printing, clerical formation, and the continuing use of approved books.

The first edition does not yet arrange this material as the later title XI or title XII with three numbered chapters. It prints one section, *De exorcizandis obsessis a daemonio*, whose preliminary norms lead into the prayers. References

to “the Roman exorcism” must consequently identify an edition and locus rather than treating every book from 1614 to the twentieth century as textually identical.

6.2 The surviving book fixes a narrow historical claim

The edition used here is the Rome printing of 1614 from the press of the Apostolic Camera, represented by the Biblioteca Universitaria Alessandrina copy. In that witness the section occupies printed pages 198–219. Those coordinates identify a bounded unit in one edition rather than an abstract text assembled from later handbooks, translations, and devotional reprints. The witness can establish the section’s order, headings, rubrics, and Latin wording. It cannot by itself establish which earlier sources supplied every phrase, how rapidly the book circulated, or what a priest in a particular diocese actually did.

This distinction prevents a bibliographic shortcut. A later printing that calls the material a numbered title or divides it into chapters is evidence for that later editorial state, not a transparent window onto the architecture of 1614. Conversely, the absence of later supplementary material from the first edition does not make that material unofficial in a period when competent authority subsequently approved it. Textual descent, book structure, juridical status, and practical reception require separate evidence.

6.3 The preliminary norms are part of the historical evidence

Read as a whole, the 1614 section resists the caricature of an incautious collection of commands. It warns the exorcist not to believe readily that someone is possessed; to distinguish possession from melancholy or other illness; to avoid credulity toward what the afflicted person says; to reject curiosity, superstition, divination, superfluous or indecent questions, and theatrical display; to leave medicine to physicians; to rely on prayer, fasting, Scripture, and the sacraments; and to conduct the ministry with humility and moral seriousness. These are paraphrases of the section’s preliminary cautions, not a usable digest of its procedure.

The order of presentation is itself evidence. The book addresses the minister’s judgment, conduct, and spiritual disposition before the ritual speech that follows. It therefore frames the rite as an ecclesial act governed by office and discipline, not as a freestanding collection of potent words. This observation does not require the prayers to be reprinted. Reprinting them would instead blur the difference between a history of the book and a surrogate ritual manual.

The title also reflects its period. Its differential language is pre-psychiatric; its inherited signs are not a contemporary self-test; and its assumptions about bodily disorder cannot be detached from early-modern medicine. Yet its first act is epistemic restraint. The book requires a judgment, acknowledges false attribution, and disciplines the minister before it supplies ritual speech. That structure is a genuine ancestor of the modern Church’s insistence that authority and careful discernment precede a major exorcism, even though modern safeguards and clinical knowledge are not simply latent in a seventeenth-century manual.

What may and may not be inferred from the book

The printed title proves what Roman authority prescribed and what a priest using that edition could read. It does not prove how frequently the rite was used, that every local exorcist followed it, that a reported case was possession, or that an attributed outcome occurred. Normative text, local practice, case narration, and theological judgment remain four different evidence classes.

6.4 Prescription, permission, and reception are not synonyms

Four questions must remain separate when the 1614 book is used as historical evidence. What did the printed Roman text prescribe to its intended minister? What authority did the book claim and how was it commended for use? Which local churches or communities received it, and on what timescale? What happened in a reported individual case? The Alessandrina witness directly answers only the first two at the level of the book. Reception requires diocesan books, statutes, visitation records, library evidence, or comparable local controls. A case requires its own contemporary documentary chain.

This four-part distinction blocks opposite shortcuts. Printing an official formulary does not prove universal compliance or an alleged cure. Evidence that a local ritual remained in use does not make the Roman book irrelevant. A reported abuse does not establish the meaning of the normative text, while a cautious norm does not prove that every minister obeyed it. Books, authorities, ministers, communities, and reported events are related evidence without being interchangeable.

6.5 Standardization, revision, and expansion

Successive Roman editions preserved the basic material while changing rubrics, arrangement, and supplementary material. The blessing of persons or places and the exorcism associated with Leo XIII belong to their own textual and juridical histories; neither the later three-chapter architecture nor its third chapter may be folded backward into the 1614 formulary. By the twentieth century the commonly cited predecessor is title XII of the 1952 *Rituale Romanum*. That book is important evidence for the discipline immediately before the postconciliar revision, but its existence does not settle whether, where, or under what authorization an older book may be used today.

The edition history should therefore be read as a sequence of controlled states, not as one frozen “1614 rite.” For each state the questions are bibliographic before they are interpretive: who authorized it, what decree or title page identifies it, how is the material divided, what changed at the relevant locus, and what evidence establishes the change? Until those controls are present, a date in a later bibliography remains a research lead rather than proof of a textual revision. This study uses the 1614 witness for its own section and the 1952 edition only as the identified title-XII predecessor to the postconciliar reform; it does not claim a complete line-by-line stemma between them.

The Leonine material especially requires this discipline. Its documentary questions include the authority and wording of the original act, later revision, placement in particular editions, and subsequent restrictions on use. A devotional origin story, however familiar, cannot answer those questions. Nor can a formula directed against Satan and the apostate angels be silently equated with the 1614 section concerning an allegedly possessed person. Their objects, textual histories, and disciplinary reception must be narrated separately.

The durable achievement of 1614 was therefore narrower and more important than folklore suggests. It placed extraordinary ministry inside an official pastoral book, subordinated ritual action to ministerial discipline and discernment, and supplied a stable textual point against which later law and revision could work. Its cautions are not decorative preliminaries: they are part of the rite’s institutional meaning.

7 Codification and Modern Liturgical Reform

7.1 From ritual-book discipline to codified reservation

The 1917 *Codex Iuris Canonici* made the jurisdictional boundary explicit. Canon 1151 required one exercising exorcistic power received through ordination never to proceed against the possessed without the ordinary’s express and particular permission; the ordinary was to grant it only to a priest distinguished by piety, prudence, and integrity of life. Canon 1152 extended the lawful use of exorcisms by legitimate ministers beyond Catholics and catechumens, while canon 1153 left the minister of exorcisms within baptism, consecrations, and blessings to the relevant approved rites. These are three related rules, not one undifferentiated reservation. Canon 1151 also required a diligent and prudent investigation establishing that the person was truly possessed before the authorized priest proceeded. Permission regulated licit ministry and did not itself adjudicate the alleged cause.

Codification also changed the kind of evidence a historian must use. A ritual book supplies liturgical text and rubrics; a code supplies universal juridical norms. The code did not make every exorcistic text in every ritual book interchangeable, and a ritual book did not replace the code’s rule about authorization. After 1917, an account must therefore identify both the edition of the rite and the law governing its minister. A later ritual edition adapted to codified law belongs to this interaction of books; ritual text and canon law did not become one document.

The 1983 code states the core rule more concisely. Canon 1172 forbids anyone to perform exorcisms legitimately over the possessed without particular and express permission from the local ordinary, and says that permission is to be given only to a priest distinguished by piety, knowledge, prudence, and integrity of life. This is universal law for the Latin Church as of 26 July 2026. The Holy See’s published register of authentic interpretations contains none for

canon 1172, and no material amendment was located in the official legal sources checked through that date. The canon neither licenses lay major exorcism nor converts the grant of permission into a finding that every presented phenomenon has a preternatural cause.

7.2 Revision of the ritual book

The postconciliar revision did not begin from a claim that evil or exorcism had ceased to be Catholic subjects. It revised a sacramental within the principles governing the Roman Ritual, with renewed scriptural proclamation, distinct forms of prayer, and revised preliminary norms. The decree dated 22 November 1998 promulgated *De Exorcismis et Supplicationibus Quibusdam*; the Latin typical edition was issued in 1999 and publicly presented on 26 January. An emended reprint followed in 2004; it should not be mislabeled a second typical edition. Edition, emendation, translation, confirmation, and territorial implementation are separate acts. A 2021 dicastery decree also adjusted the book's preliminary norm on episcopal-conference translations to conform to amended canon 838. The proprietary formularies are not reproduced here.

The dates identify different documentary events. The decree of 22 November 1998 is the act of promulgation. The 1999 volume is the Latin typical edition in which the revised rite was issued, and 26 January 1999 is the date of its public presentation. The 2004 volume is an emended reprint of that typical edition. Treating all four references as a single publication date hides the difference between juridical act, material edition, public explanation, and corrected textual state. Calling the 2004 state a second typical edition would create an authority claim the identified sources do not make.

The revised volume also marks a different editorial situation from the comprehensive 1952 *Rituale Romanum*. It is a distinct postconciliar ritual volume, not simply a new chapter silently inserted into title XII. Continuity must therefore be demonstrated at the level claimed. Continuity of ecclesial purpose, episcopal governance, prayer, Scripture, and prudent discernment does not prove verbal identity. Changed structure, preliminary norms, and formularies do not prove theological repudiation of everything that preceded them.

The Congregation's 1999 presentation begins from Christ's ministry and describes discernment in terms of prudential certainty. It also situates the rite among prayer, Scripture, and ecclesial authority rather than popular spectacle. That official presentation establishes the reform's stated theological and pastoral rationale. It does not supply prevalence data or validate retrospective case claims.

How this study compares ritual books

The comparison is limited to promulgation, edition identity, book structure, the authority and conduct of the minister, categories of discernment, and the official rationale for revision. It does not reproduce prayers, adjurations, lists of alleged signs, or the order of actions. Those omissions preserve the difference between historical analysis and an operational rite.

7.3 Discipline against unauthorized imitation

Two doctrinal interventions close a common loophole. The Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith's letter of 29 September 1985 (the official page's URL contains "19850924," but the Latin heading and AAS citation give 29 September) required observance of canon 1172, prohibited the faithful's use of the Leonine formula against Satan and the apostate angels, and directed ordinaries to prevent persons lacking the requisite power from conducting assemblies in which demons were directly addressed and their identity sought. The *Instruction on Prayers for Healing* (2000), article 8, again separates liturgical exorcism from healing services and places the matter under the diocesan bishop. Calling an event a prayer meeting, healing ministry, or deliverance session does not erase those boundaries.

The 1985 letter also prevents a false inference from textual availability. Possessing, copying, translating, or finding an older formula does not confer the power or permission whose absence the letter addresses. The document is not merely a warning about poor technique; it protects a boundary between the Church's authorized liturgical act and unauthorized assemblies that imitate some of its speech. A historical appendix of formulas would therefore be pastorally misleading even if rights permitted it.

The *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, no. 1673, provides doctrinal and catechetical orientation rather than a second grant of the particular and express permission required by canon 1172: simple exorcism occurs in baptism; solemn or

“major” exorcism may be performed only by a priest with episcopal permission; and illness, especially psychological illness, is a different matter whose treatment belongs to medical science. It says that before celebration it is important to ascertain that the matter concerns the presence of the Evil One rather than illness. That is an explicit differential warning, not a clinical test or a replacement for canon 1172 and the ritual norms.

7.4 Territorial implementation and the United States

For the Latin dioceses of the United States, the bishops’ conference reports that the English *Exorcisms and Related Supplications* received Holy See confirmation in December 2016 and was implemented on 29 June 2017. Its public guidance describes consultation with medical and mental-health professionals, the search for moral certitude, consent, privacy, and the distinction between minor and major exorcism. These are authoritative facts about U.S. implementation and official pastoral guidance. They should not be rewritten as universal procedural law or as a clinical protocol.

7.5 Universal law, typical edition, and territorial book

Three levels operate together without collapsing into one another. Canon 1172 supplies universal Latin law concerning the authorized minister. The Latin typical edition supplies the controlling liturgical edition for its own text and structure. An approved and confirmed vernacular edition supplies a territorial liturgical book under the applicable law. Conference guidance may then explain implementation in that territory. A statement true at one level does not automatically acquire the scope of another.

This layered structure matters for translation history. Translation is not merely the substitution of vernacular words for Latin words: competent approval, Holy See confirmation under the governing discipline, and a stated implementation date identify the ecclesial edition. Likewise, the 2021 adjustment to the preliminary norm concerning conference translations belongs to the book’s current juridical-liturgical setting. It cannot be retrojected into the circumstances of either 1614 or 1952.

Historical layer	What changed	What remained
1917 code	Particular permission and the minister’s qualifications were codified.	Authorization remained episcopally governed and did not prove the alleged cause.
1983 code	The universal rule was restated more concisely in canon 1172.	Major exorcism remained reserved to an expressly authorized priest.
1998/2004 ritual	A 1998 decree promulgated the rite; the 1999 typical edition received an emended reprint in 2004.	Scripture, ecclesial prayer, discernment, and episcopal authority continued to frame the ministry.
U.S. 2017 implementation	An approved English edition entered use territorially.	Universal law and territorial implementation remained distinct.

Modern reform is thus neither abolition nor a simple survival of 1614. It is a rearticulation in which concise canon law, a revised ritual book, doctrinal instructions, and local implementation act together. Any present claim about an older book requires a separate legal and liturgical showing; historical continuity alone supplies no permission.

8 Historical Cases: What a Dossier Could Establish

A named case can illuminate the history of exorcism without deciding whether a person was possessed. It may show, for example, how a bishop understood his authority, how physicians and clergy divided competence, how a court assigned responsibility, how a printed narrative was reshaped, or how a community remembered an event. Those are historical questions about identifiable acts and witnesses. They are different from an attempt to infer an invisible cause from a retrospective collection of reported symptoms.

This study nevertheless excludes famous named cases from its narrative. Loudun, Illfurth, Earling, and Klingenberg were tested during source review, but no case-specific work, artifact, passage, or controlled corpus was bound to this publication. The available leads did not supply the exact contemporary and official records needed for the proposed dates, authorizations, medical or judicial claims, outcomes, and later judgments. Naming the cases here records the bounded exclusion; it does not endorse the details circulated about them.

8.1 The claim determines the evidence threshold

Case evidence should be admitted proportionately rather than by an all-or-nothing rule. A study of one participant's testimony may begin with a controlled edition of that testimony and scholarship on its authorship, editing, and transmission. It can establish what the witness says and how the text was formed; it cannot establish that every narrated event occurred. A study of an institutional controversy requires independently controlled contemporary positions and the relevant episcopal, religious, civil, or judicial act. A study of injury, diagnosis, liability, or safeguarding requires the competent medical, forensic, or legal record for each such claim. No quantity of memoir, press repetition, or later devotional reception can substitute for those controlling records.

This proportional rule prevents two opposite errors. It does not demand a complete archive before making a narrow claim that one surviving witness can actually support. It also does not let a narrow witness support a complete story. Missing source families must be named, and the claims that depend on them remain outside the narrative.

8.2 A case dossier before a case narrative

Before prose is drafted, a case dossier should record:

1. the precise historical question and the strongest conclusion the proposed evidence could support;
2. a chronology of alleged events distinct from the chronology of surviving documents, editions, and later judgments;
3. the provenance, genre, authorship, date, intended audience, and exact locus of each retained witness;
4. the competent authority and exact scope of any permission, prohibition, investigation, decree, judgment, diagnosis, or finding;
5. the dependencies among later narratives, so that several retellings of one account are not counted as independent corroboration;
6. material agreements and conflicts, including silence where a source would reasonably be expected to speak;
7. the rights, privacy, dignity, and safeguarding boundary for naming a person or reproducing sensitive material; and
8. an evidence-map entry for every retained date, identity, proceeding, outcome, and interpretive hinge.

The resulting narrative must keep the witness's act separate from the event the witness reports. An episcopal permission establishes that permission was given within its recorded terms; it does not authenticate possession. A clinical record establishes an examination and its professional judgment; it does not decide a metaphysical question. A judicial finding controls what the court decided under the applicable law and evidence; it is not an ecclesiastical judgment. A later ecclesiastical statement establishes that later act and its scope, not an undocumented earlier event.

8.3 Questions a case cannot settle

Historical method supplies no controlled assay for a preternatural cause. Accordingly, a case study in this work would not declare that possession, fraud, or a modern diagnosis has been proved merely by fitting a retrospective pattern. Nor would reported improvement establish ritual efficacy: the account may lack an independent outcome measure, may select successful episodes, or may depend on the minister's own narrative. Conversely, a natural differential or a documented human failure does not by itself settle every theological proposition about spirits.

These distinctions are not evasions. They allow a case to carry the historical weight its sources can bear. They also prevent uncertainty in one discipline from becoming positive evidence for another explanation.

8.4 Why exclusion remains the present result

A later historian, clerical narrative, devotional pamphlet, press account, recording, film, or local commemoration may be evidence for its own act of reception. It does not silently become the missing archive. Current rules on reservation, privacy, professional consultation, consent, and continuing care stand on current official sources; they do not need a sensational retrospective case to justify them.

Named cases may therefore be restored only after case-specific acquisition and review identify the controlling records, exact loci, provenance, narrative dependencies, material conflicts, and limited conclusion each witness can support. Until then, exclusion protects historical accuracy and the dignity of the persons involved while leaving open the possibility of a later, genuinely source-controlled case study.

9 Catholic demonology: doctrine, inference, and restraint

The Church's discipline makes sense only within a sharply asymmetrical theology. God is uncreated goodness, the source of every creature and every power creatures possess. Lateran IV teaches that the devil and other demons were created good by nature but became evil by their own doing (const. 1, *Firmiter credimus*, DS 800). The Catechism identifies them as fallen angels, describes their rejection of God as free and irrevocable, and insists that Satan remains a creature whose finite action is permitted by providence (CCC 391–395). Evil is therefore neither an eternal principle nor a second sovereignty.

This is doctrine. Many details supplied by later demonologies are not. The existence and fall of personal evil spirits, their opposition to God's reign, their temptation of human beings, Christ's victory, and the final defeat of evil belong to the Church's received confession (CCC 391–395, 550, 2850–2854). This study's authority audit found no defined status for elaborate ranks or territorial assignments, non-scriptural names, causal explanations of a particular misfortune, or pastoral taxonomies of "infestation," "oppression," and "obsession." Such terms may distinguish questions in a particular school or pastoral setting; repetition does not make them dogma.

9.1 Natural, preternatural, and supernatural

For the bounded purposes of this study, these school-theological terms mark relations, not three kinds of being. The definitions that follow are an editorial synthesis used to keep kinds of claim distinct; the three-word scheme is not presented as a definition of doctrine. *Natural* refers to a creature and to powers and effects proportioned to a created nature. Catholic writers may call an alleged effect *preternatural* when they attribute it to a created spiritual power beyond the ordinary capacities of embodied human agents. An angel or demon is nevertheless a creature with an angelic nature, not a "preternatural substance." *Supernatural* refers to God and to the order exceeding every created nature: uncreated divine life and created gifts of grace by which creatures participate in it.

These are metaphysical classifications, not diagnostic test results. A surprising event does not become preternatural because its natural explanation is not yet known. "Unexplained" describes an epistemic state; it does not name a cause. Conversely, Catholic theology does not require that the preternatural be redefined as an unknown natural mechanism. It permits the question while refusing a shortcut from possibility to case judgment.

The same distinction governs medicine. A clinician can diagnose, treat, or exclude conditions within professional competence. Clinical evidence cannot demonstrate that no created spirit exists; neither can a theological belief diagnose epilepsy, psychosis, dissociation, delirium, intoxication, or trauma. At the direct intersection—a living person's symptoms and safety—current U.S. pastoral guidance calls for competent medical and psychological or psychiatric assessment. This is a safeguarding discipline, not a clinical test for a spiritual cause (CCC 1673; USCCB, "Exorcism").

9.2 Temptation, sin, and responsibility

The ordinary Christian doctrine of temptation is broader and more important than extraordinary claims. Being tempted is distinct from consenting: personal sin results from morally attributable consent. Responsibility follows voluntariness, so ignorance, duress, fear, habit, and psychological or social factors may diminish or nullify imputability;

mortal sin requires grave matter, full knowledge, and deliberate consent (CCC 1734–1735, 1857, 1859, 2846–2847). Neither grave sin nor persistent habit proves direct demonic action. Persons remain moral subjects even when freedom or knowledge is impaired. Attributing harmful conduct to possession can displace accountability, blame a harmed person, stigmatize illness, or conceal abuse.

In Aquinas’s scholastic analysis, demons neither know secret thoughts as they exist in intellect and will nor move the will inwardly or by necessity. They may infer dispositions from outward effects, persuade through an apparent good, rouse passions, and affect imagination or sense through bounded bodily causality; the will remains able to consent or resist (ST I, q. 57, a. 4; q. 111, aa. 2–4; q. 114, aa. 2–3). Aquinas also denies that every sin comes from direct demonic instigation. This metaphysical account is neither defined clinical mechanism nor a warrant for attributing a particular symptom.

9.3 Possession and the integrity of the person

In Catholic pastoral usage, alleged possession concerns extraordinary affliction attributed to demonic power; it never means that a human being has become a demon. The person remains the subject of human dignity and care (CCC 1700–1706). An allegation does not authorize treating every utterance during distress as a spirit’s speech, ignoring disclosures of pain or abuse, or relabeling refusal as demonic resistance. Capacity must be assessed, consent sought wherever possible, and ordinary legal and safeguarding protections preserved (CCC 1673; USCCB, “Exorcism”).

The rite is directed toward liberation through Christ and the prayer of the Church. It is not punishment, interrogation, evidence extraction, or an ordeal designed to force a reaction. The person seeking or referred for care is never the enemy. This Christological boundary is more fundamental than any proposed sign: Christ has no equal rival, and the Church’s ministry seeks liberation rather than spectacle or domination (CCC 550, 1673).

9.4 Doctrine, sacramental, and authorization

Three affirmations that often appear together answer different questions. First, doctrine identifies the creaturely reality of evil spirits, Christ’s victory, and the dignity of the afflicted person. Second, the Church classifies exorcism among the sacramentals: sacred signs obtain principally spiritual effects through the Church’s intercession (CIC c. 1166; CCC 1667, 1673). Third, Latin law reserves licit exorcism over the possessed to a qualified priest who has obtained the local ordinary’s particular and express permission (CIC c. 1172). Doctrine supplies neither a diagnosis nor an appointment; the definition of a sacramental supplies neither permission nor jurisdiction.

The word *exorcist* consequently requires a dated context. It may denote a holder of an ancient or medieval ecclesial grade, the minor order discussed in scholastic and later Latin sources, or a priest permitted to undertake the reserved ministry under current Latin law. Those are not interchangeable offices. Aquinas’s placement of exorcists among ministers assisting the priest in baptismal preparation (ST III, q. 71, a. 4) does not confer the permission required by canon 1172, describe a current diocesan post, or prove habitual practice of major exorcism.

Nor does permission settle the factual judgment that precedes ritual action. The Catechism’s statement that major exorcism may be performed only by a priest with episcopal permission gives catechetical orientation (CCC 1673); canon 1172 states the legal requirement as particular and express permission from the local ordinary. Neither proposition turns authorization into proof that a person is possessed. The office or administrative arrangement by which a diocese receives referrals, the authority competent to give permission, and the discernment of a particular presentation remain distinct.

9.5 Angels, saints, sacramentals, and magic

Sacramentals are sacred signs instituted by the Church; through her intercession they signify and obtain effects, especially spiritual ones. They do not confer grace in the manner of the sacraments, but prepare persons to receive grace and dispose them to cooperate with it (CIC c. 1166; CCC 1667, 1670). Their use is not a mechanism under the user’s control: attributing efficacy to mere external performance apart from the dispositions it calls for is superstition (CCC 2111). Blessed objects are not talismans and sacred words are not incantations. The materiality of a sign does not make it magic. The decisive contrasts are petition rather than control, ecclesial worship rather than self-authorized

technique, and trust in God rather than an attempt to tame occult powers or place them at one’s service (CCC 2116–2117).

Invoking angels or saints within received Christian prayer differs from seeking secret names, bargaining with spirits, divination, necromancy, or coercive technique (CCC 2116–2117). Curiosity about a demon’s identity has no pastoral claim over the person’s dignity. The CDF’s letter of 29 September 1985 forbids direct questioning aimed at learning a demon’s identity in the unauthorized prayer gatherings it addresses. That precise restriction should not be expanded into a description of an authorized rite. Historical ritual questions are not reader-facing instructions.

Editorial synthesis: the doctrinal center

Christian demonology is a small province within creation, providence, Christology, and redemption. Its central propositions are that evil is creaturely and parasitic, Christ is victorious, human dignity remains, and the Church’s prayer depends on God. A system that produces fascination, fatalism, fear of ordinary medicine, or contempt for an afflicted person has lost that center even when it uses traditional vocabulary.

10 The Latin rule and the Eastern boundary

No universal sentence about “the Catholic rite of exorcism” is safe unless it names a Church, book, minister, and juridical scope. This study establishes one necessary boundary: the 1983 *Codex Iuris Canonici* governs the Latin Church, while CCEO canon 1 says that the Eastern Code concerns all and only the Eastern Catholic Churches unless it expressly provides otherwise about relations with the Latin Church. Canon 2 requires the Eastern canons to be assessed principally from the ancient law they receive or adapt. Latin canon 1172 therefore may not be silently transplanted as though it were an Eastern canon.

10.1 The Latin reservation

In the Latin Church, canon 1172 makes particular and express permission of the local ordinary necessary for licit exorcism over the possessed. Permission may be given only to a priest marked by piety, knowledge, prudence, and integrity. The revised *De Exorcismis et Supplicationibus Quibusdam* supplies the liturgical discipline. The universal law identifies neither a permanent diocesan office nor a universal intake system; concrete diocesan arrangements therefore require their own territorial and local controls.

Question	What the bound source establishes	What it does not establish
Minister	Canon 1172 restricts the permission to a priest with the stated qualities.	Priesthood alone does not confer permission for the reserved act.
Permission	It must be particular and express and must come from the local ordinary.	It is not supplied by a family, prayer group, lay association, or the priest’s private judgment.
Office	A diocese may make practical arrangements for receiving and assigning cases.	Canon 1172 does not itself create a permanent diocesan office, title, intake system, or territorial protocol.
Case judgment	Permission regulates who may act licitly.	The grant does not by itself prove possession or displace continuing discernment and care.
Ritual governance	Approved liturgical law governs the ecclesial act; the typical book and confirmed territorial editions must be distinguished.	Historical possession of an older book or a privately preferred formula does not establish present authorization.

This separation also disciplines the word “jurisdiction.” Canon 1172 names the *local ordinary*; the Catechism summarizes the pastoral rule as episcopal permission (CCC 1673); and the 2000 instruction places liturgical exorcism under the diocesan bishop. These formulations should be reported at their own levels rather than collapsed into an undefined claim that any bishop or any ecclesiastical superior may authorize the act anywhere. The bound sources in

this study do not resolve cross-diocesan cases, the competence of particular vicars, personal jurisdictions, religious institutes, or the duration and revocation of a grant. Those questions require the applicable universal and particular law, the competent authority's act, and the facts of place and person.

The permission is not a declaration that possession has been proved. It is particular and express authorization for a reserved ecclesial act; ordination alone does not supply it, a lay association cannot delegate it, and a family cannot create it by consent. The 1985 CDF letter also governs assemblies in which no exorcism strictly so called is performed but demons are directly addressed and their identities are sought. The 2000 instruction on healing prayers keeps exorcism distinct from healing services and under the diocesan bishop. These interventions close attempts to evade the reservation by changing an event's label; they do not convert every prayer for deliverance into the major exorcism governed by canon 1172.

Territorial implementation remains subordinate. The USCCB's public account identifies the confirmed English book and a responsible American pattern: medical and psychological assessment, moral certitude, consent where possible, privacy, limited participation, and fidelity to the rite. It is official conference guidance and an identified U.S. implementation, not universal law. A diocese elsewhere may use a different approved translation and protocol while remaining bound by canon 1172 and the typical book.

10.2 What this Latin rule does not decide

The authentic CCEO text establishes two limits relevant here: the code concerns all and only the Eastern Catholic Churches unless it expressly provides otherwise concerning relations with the Latin Church, and its canons are to be assessed principally from the ancient law of the Eastern Churches. Those provisions establish the codal boundary and interpretive context. They do not identify the minister of an Eastern exorcistic prayer, confer permission on that minister, identify the competent hierarchy, or make Latin canon 1172 an Eastern norm.

This study did not verify the common, particular, and liturgical law needed to state a major-exorcism rule for any identified Eastern Catholic Church. It therefore neither asserts that the CCEO contains an equivalent of canon 1172 nor treats failure to locate one as permission to act. It likewise makes no claim about the present law or practice of an Orthodox Church. A safe comparison would require the exact Church, competent authority, approved book, language, date, and kind of prayer; none can be supplied by transferring a Latin rule or by citing a generic "Eastern rite."

The same caution applies to apparent parallels in vocabulary. A named Eastern office, a prayer called an exorcism, episcopal supervision, and authority to use a particular book would remain four claims requiring their own sources. Similarity to a Latin title or formula cannot establish the identity of the office, the reservation of the act, or the jurisdiction of the minister. Until those sources are bound, the responsible conclusion is a boundary, not a synthetic "Catholic procedure."

11 Discernment, consent, and safeguarding

Discernment is not a hunt for confirming signs. It is an accountable process that protects a person while several hypotheses remain open. The Church's theological permission to consider a preternatural cause never removes the duty to investigate natural danger, illness, coercion, fraud, trauma, and social context. The USCCB's official account therefore places medical and psychological or psychiatric evaluation within the inquiry and urges great circumspection.

11.1 Different questions, different competences

Medical and mental-health assessment belongs to appropriately qualified professionals. Relevant differential questions can include symptoms, functioning, safety, physical and neurological conditions, medicines and substances, sleep, trauma, dissociation, mood, psychosis, and cultural or religious context. The WHO's ICD-11 clinical descriptions distinguish culturally accepted practices, substances, sleep-transition states, neurological disease, trauma-related and dissociative conditions, delirium, and psychotic disorders. That classification neither proves nor disproves a preternatural cause. Pastoral and ecclesial judgments remain distinct from diagnosis and treatment.

Clinical findings and pastoral judgments should be communicated with consent and within privacy law and professional ethics. A clinician need not affirm a preternatural explanation to provide competent care. A priest should not ask

a clinician for a certificate that “rules out every natural cause,” an impossible standard. The goal is a morally responsible judgment under uncertainty, not the elimination of all conceivable doubt.

Culture can shape how distress is described, explained, and addressed. The USCCB’s United States guidance therefore calls cultural and regional awareness helpful in discernment. Asking how the person and social network understand a problem, what help has been tried, and what care is sought neither makes a culturally framed experience self-proving pathology nor decides an ecclesial attribution.

11.2 Consent and capacity

Consent is not a decorative courtesy. The USCCB states that the person’s consent should be ascertained if at all possible. Responsible practice explains the pastoral nature of the inquiry, who will be present, what information may be shared, and that medical care should continue. Capacity is decision- and time-specific and must be assessed by competent persons under applicable law. The person should be supported to participate as fully as possible. Clinical emergency and surrogate decisions follow civil law and clinical ethics; they do not create permission for a non-emergency religious rite. A person with capacity may refuse or withdraw from a non-emergency religious inquiry or rite; that refusal must not be relabeled spiritual resistance. Rules for minors, incapacity, and surrogate decisions remain jurisdiction-specific.

Family fear does not itself confer authority over an adult. For a minor, parental or guardian involvement, the child’s participation, and protective duties depend on applicable safeguarding law and policy. No ritual claim authorizes restraint, confinement, food or sleep deprivation, medication withdrawal, pain, humiliation, or prolonged questioning.

11.3 Privacy without secrecy

The USCCB’s United States guidance says confidentiality is important for the reputation of the afflicted person and assistants. Case records, recordings, and disclosures should follow applicable law, diocesan safeguarding policy, and the professional duties of those involved. They are not evidence of cause merely because they are dramatic.

The USCCB also discourages an exorcist from working alone and places the authorized minister under episcopal direction. Confidentiality does not displace reporting, emergency, or protective-disclosure duties where applicable law requires them.

11.4 Abuse patterns

Official safeguarding material for England documents the cross-religious problem of child abuse linked to accusations of witchcraft or spirit possession. That territorial record does not establish Catholic prevalence or a worldwide rate. It does establish the controlling safeguarding point: violence, emotional harm, neglect, coercion, trafficking, and exploitation remain abuse when justified through spiritual accusations. Catholic teaching condemns such conduct independently of whether perpetrators claimed sincere belief. A preternatural explanation cannot legalize assault or neglect.

Less visible harms also matter: telling a child he is inhabited by evil; teaching a survivor that trauma symptoms prove complicity; blaming disability or sexual orientation on a spirit; repeatedly eliciting lurid narratives; isolating a person from skeptical relatives; demanding money; or making relief depend on obedience to an unaccountable minister. Such labeling can itself inflict emotional harm. Other coercive practices risk fear, stigma, dependency, family conflict, and retraumatization.

Safeguarding therefore examines relationships and incentives, not only ritual text. Who has authority? Who can stop the process? Is care conditioned on payment, publicity, or loyalty? Are allegations against another person being reported to competent civil and ecclesial authorities rather than “treated” as a spirit? Does the team recognize domestic violence, trafficking, abuse, self-harm, and medical emergency?

11.5 Emergency and continuing care

Imminent risk of serious self-harm or violence, sudden confusion, medical instability, suspected poisoning, or abuse calls for urgent medical, mental-health, emergency, or protective action appropriate to the jurisdiction. Prayer may accompany care; it may not replace it. Changes to prescribed medicines should be discussed with the prescribing clinician.

Ordinary pastoral care continues whether or not major exorcism is considered: safe prayer, sacramental care appropriate to the person, medical treatment, therapy, and practical support. A decision not to authorize a major rite is not abandonment. Nor does celebration make indicated professional care or safeguarding unnecessary.

A safeguarding test

Any claimed ministry fails before its extraordinary hypothesis is reached if it bypasses emergency care, suppresses medical treatment, coerces consent, isolates the person, uses violence or humiliation, conceals abuse, monetizes fear, publishes the case, or lacks accountable ecclesial authority.

12 Culture, reception, and the strongest objections

Film, memoir, podcast, viral testimony, and exposé are mediated accounts, not clinical records or prevalence data. This study therefore does not use them to establish diagnosis, efficacy, or frequency. The Church's public discipline instead emphasizes authorization, circumspection, professional consultation, consent where possible, and confidentiality.

12.1 How reception changes a case

Reception is historically important even when it cannot authenticate the event being retold. A private pastoral encounter may become a clerical narrative, devotional example, newspaper controversy, entertainment property, or online testimony. At each stage, selection and genre change what the audience receives. A memoir organizes memory around an author's later understanding. Journalism compresses a dossier into reportable conflict. Film supplies scenes, dialogue, causal sequence, and resolution whether or not the archive does. A short online extract can detach a voice or gesture from the circumstances in which it was recorded.

The historical question must therefore follow the artifact. A film can show how an era imagined exorcism; it cannot prove the event it dramatizes. A memoir can establish what its author later asserted; it cannot become an independent clinical or diocesan record. A recording can preserve sounds made at a particular session only after provenance and context are controlled; it does not identify their cause. Audience size, repetition, and emotional force measure reception, not prevalence or efficacy.

This distinction also applies to hostile reception. An exposé may document a real institutional failure when it supplies controlled records, but the label "exposé" does not itself establish its allegations. A skeptical retelling and a devotional retelling remain dependent witnesses if both ultimately derive their chronology from the same unexamined narrative.

12.2 The ethics of public evidence

Availability is not permission and publicity is not harmlessness. Case records may disclose health information, trauma, family conflict, spiritual direction, or the identity of a vulnerable person. Recordings and transcripts can become spectacles detached from consent and context. A responsible history asks not only whether material is accessible, but whether naming, quotation, or reproduction is necessary to the historical claim, lawful, and proportionate to the foreseeable harm.

Anonymization also has limits. A famous chronology may identify a person even after a name is removed, while aggressive abstraction may make the evidence impossible to audit. Where those duties cannot be reconciled, the proper result may be a source-audited institutional history without intimate case detail.

12.3 The secular-clinical objection

The strongest naturalist objection is not merely “demons do not exist.” It argues that every observable feature offered as evidence is mediated by human bodies, minds, expectations, and institutions; that possession idioms vary culturally; that naturally caused illness may be missed; and that no validated clinical test identifies a preternatural cause. History supplies fraud, misdiagnosis, and abuse. Therefore, the objection concludes, introducing demons adds no explanatory value and creates preventable risk.

Catholic theology should concede the empirical and moral force of much of this case. Observable ambiguity, cultural shaping, and risks from delayed or inappropriate care are reasons for restriction and consultation. The Church does not possess a laboratory assay for possession. The philosophical conclusion does not follow by empirical method alone: clinical sciences rightly study natural mechanisms and need not pronounce on every created spiritual cause. But a metaphysical possibility earns no case judgment without evidence. The Catholic answer must therefore be both realist and disciplined: preternatural agency is possible; natural care and safeguarding are obligatory; an extraordinary attribution is rare, ecclesial, and morally burdened.

12.4 The Protestant objections

Protestant traditions are not one position. Many evangelicals and Pentecostals affirm continuing spiritual conflict and direct deliverance prayer, while often rejecting Catholic sacramentals, priestly reservation, or episcopal control as unscriptural. Reformed cessationists may regard apostolic exorcisms as signs tied to Christ and the apostles, question later rites, and stress preaching, discipline, and ordinary prayer. Other Protestants interpret possession narratives principally through ancient cosmology or illness.

The strongest shared challenge asks where Scripture authorizes a proprietary post-apostolic rite and whether institutional control protects truth or monopolizes a gift of the Spirit. The Catholic reply distinguishes the apostolic reality from a frozen manual. Scripture depicts Christ authorizing ministry, the Church ordering gifts, and borrowed technique failing. The later reservation is a disciplinary judgment within the Church’s authority over public worship, intended to protect persons and the integrity of prayer. It does not teach that only priests may ask God for deliverance in ordinary Christian prayer.

Catholic criticism also runs the other way. A decentralized ministry may lack case review, clinical consultation, safeguarding, and a route of appeal. Repetition of direct commands, public testimony, or the search for named spirits can increase pressure, publicity, and risk of harm. This criticism must be applied first to Catholic practice wherever it acquires the same defects.

12.5 The Orthodox objection

Orthodox critics may see the Latin revised rite and juridical discussion as over-systematized, detached from ascetic and sacramental life, or too willing to isolate extraordinary ministry from fasting, repentance, and the Church’s continuous prayer. Some also contest Latin claims about jurisdiction and the later history of sacramentals.

The objection usefully restores the baptismal, liturgical, and therapeutic horizon. The Latin answer need not deny it: the revised discipline also orders the ministry to Christ, Scripture, sacraments, and pastoral care. The real ecclesiological disagreements cannot be solved inside a study of exorcism. Nor may one Orthodox book or dramatic clerical practice be treated as “the Orthodox view.” Both traditions face the same safeguarding question: antiquity and sanctity of intention do not excuse coercion or neglect.

12.6 The Catholic traditionalist objection

Some traditionalist criticism holds that the 1998/2004 rite weakened the 1614 tradition by reducing imperative formulas, adopting modern psychological caution, or expressing uncertainty where the older book spoke plainly. A related claim treats reported preference among exorcists as proof of the older rite’s superior efficacy.

The historical questions deserve textual study, but memoir preference is not a controlled comparison and “more confrontational” is not a theological measure of efficacy. The current typical book has competent authority; older

use depends on current applicable law and the competent authority's particular and express permission, not private judgment. Psychological and medical consultation does not deny demons; it recognizes natural causes and the moral cost of error. Legitimate criticism may examine translation, pastoral prudence, and continuity without instructing unauthorized use or turning obedience into a referendum on anecdotes.

12.7 The feminist, disability, and trauma-informed objections

Safeguarding critics ask whether possession language can police bodies and dissent, transfer blame from perpetrators to victims, and gives male or clerical authority a sacred pretext for control. Disability advocates add that unusual movement, speech, cognition, or behavior can be misread as spiritual defect. The government safeguarding record from England documents the narrower case of children harmed after accusations tied to witchcraft or spirit possession, including children targeted because of disability, learning difficulty, or illness.

These are not external concerns that doctrine can wave away. They test whether Catholic claims about dignity are operative. A diagnosis, identity, dissent, trauma response, or disability is not evidence of possession. Allegations of abuse must be investigated as allegations against human agents, not dissolved into demon language. Consent where possible, appropriate accommodations, professional care, and safeguarding under applicable law and policy remain necessary. The Church's belief in demons increases, rather than decreases, the obligation not to make vulnerable persons carry a community's fear.

12.8 The popular-realist objection

A different critic says institutional caution is unbelief disguised as safety: the Gospels are clear, suffering people report relief, and excessive referral abandons them. This objection rightly resists contempt and a closed naturalism. But confidence is not discernment. The Gospels also center Christ rather than technique; the Church's law presupposes possibility while restricting action; and ordinary pastoral and clinical care are not rejection. A ministry that must disregard consent, medicine, evidence, or episcopal authority to display faith has confused audacity with trust.

The grouped objections converge on one demand: a Catholic account must be falsifiable at the level of conduct. Whatever cannot be settled about an extraordinary cause, violence, exploitation, concealment, unauthorized ritual, and medical neglect can be rejected now.

13 Pastoral conclusion: authority without spectacle

The history does not end with a recovered ancient technique. It ends with a more disciplined account of Christian responsibility. Exorcistic prayer grew within proclamation, initiation, ascetic struggle, care of afflicted persons, and the ordering of public worship. The modern Latin reservation is one historical and juridical form of a durable insight: extraordinary claims require accountable authority because the person can be harmed by credulity, disbelief, and curiosity alike.

13.1 What the history establishes

The sources do not yield a single ritual transmitted without change from the apostolic age. They show several histories that meet without collapsing into one another. The Gospel narratives proclaim the authority of Christ and the arrival of God's reign. Ancient apologists make public claims within the arguments of their own time. Initiatory sources place renunciation and exorcistic prayer within conversion and incorporation. Clergy lists and disciplinary acts show offices and authorization without disclosing a uniform practice. Medieval books, theological accounts, and later Roman rituals differentiate recipients, ministers, purposes, and effects. Modern law and ritual discipline inherit that history while governing a specific ecclesial act in the present.

Continuity therefore belongs first to the Christian confession and the Church's responsibility, not to an imagined invariant script. The history is continuous in its proclamation that evil is creaturely rather than divine, that Christ is victor, that prayer is not an occult mechanism, and that ministry belongs within ecclesial accountability. It is

discontinuous in terminology, books, offices, jurisdiction, and pastoral setting. These changes are not embarrassments to be hidden. They are the evidence by which a later practice can be located honestly rather than projected backward.

The negative findings matter as well. The checked evidence does not provide a global prevalence rate, a reliable success count, a universal medieval practice, a complete taxonomy of demonic activity, or a documentary basis for using famous cases as representative proof. It does not permit a biblical expression to become a modern diagnostic category or a clinical differential to decide a metaphysical question. Restraint at those boundaries is a historical conclusion, not merely an editorial disclaimer.

13.2 Different responsibilities around one person

For the person seeking help, the first question need not be “Is this possession?” It can be “What keeps you safe, cared for, and connected to truthful help today?” Emergency danger goes to emergency services. Bodily and mental symptoms deserve competent care. Abuse calls for protection and use of the reporting route required in the applicable jurisdiction. Pastoral suffering deserves patient prayer and accompaniment. A Catholic can approach a parish or diocese without first proving a theory.

For family and friends, love does not require becoming investigators. Support sleep, appointments, food, housing, prescribed care, and ordinary relationships. Do not test reactions to sacred objects, publish or circulate recordings, argue with an alleged spirit, restrain the person, or recruit an online minister. Listen without promising an explanation beyond one’s competence. Where the person’s account includes violence, self-harm, abuse, or medical danger, use the local emergency or safeguarding route rather than spiritualizing it away.

This ordinary support is not a lesser response while an extraordinary answer is awaited. Stable relationships, truthful listening, clinical care, material assistance, and ordinary pastoral life remain goods whatever conclusion is eventually reached. They also resist the isolation on which coercive ministries depend. A person should not have to accept a frightening interpretation, abandon treatment, surrender privacy, or display distress in order to remain worthy of attention.

For clergy and pastoral workers, taking a person seriously differs from ratifying every interpretation. The pastor can pray, hear, ask about immediate safety, arrange emergency or professional help when indicated, and consult diocesan authority. If the matter reaches a reserved process, authorization, supervision, consent, confidentiality, cultural attention, and applicable safeguarding requirements remain part of fidelity rather than bureaucratic obstacles to it.

The same accountability limits confidence as well as action. A minister may recognize the Church’s theological categories without claiming clinical competence, and may observe disturbing behavior without declaring its hidden cause. Referral is not abandonment; consultation is not disbelief; refusal to perform an unauthorized act is not indifference. If competent authority does not authorize the reserved rite, ordinary pastoral care does not thereby end.

For clinicians, collaboration need not require theological agreement. The Church needs honest natural assessment, not a certificate of metaphysical approval. A clinician can respectfully elicit a patient’s religious framework, assess health and safety within clinical competence, and identify harmful practices without adjudicating doctrine. Pastoral teams should be equally willing to hear when their own language or procedure is worsening symptoms.

Good collaboration preserves the difference between the questions being asked. The clinician assesses symptoms, functioning, capacity, risk, and relevant differentials within professional competence. Ecclesial authority judges what the Church may authorize under its own law and ritual discipline. Neither party serves the person by asking the other to certify a conclusion outside that party’s competence. Both remain answerable to consent, privacy, applicable law, and the need for continuing care.

For researchers and media, official caution and confidentiality limit what can be known. Absence of public data does not justify invented prevalence; a recording does not by itself establish provenance, diagnosis, or cause. This study therefore privileges identified law, ritual texts, institutional records, and safeguarding evidence over exposure of a person’s case.

13.3 Authority is a form of restraint

The history explains why authorization cannot be reduced to possession of a text or confidence in a private gift. In the Latin Church, canon 1172 governs who may act and under what permission. The ritual book governs a

liturgical act; official instructions close attempts to evade its reservation by changing the label of an event. Territorial implementation, diocesan policy, civil law, and professional duties add their own applicable controls. None of these sources proves the alleged cause merely by regulating the response.

Authority is therefore visible partly in what a responsible minister declines to do: no amateur experiment, no public performance, no coercion dressed as persistence, no displacement of treatment, and no promise of certainty the evidence cannot bear. Confidentiality protects the person, but it does not conceal abuse or override duties of emergency and protective disclosure. Consent protects freedom, but it does not authorize harmful conduct. Clinical consultation protects competent judgment, but it does not transfer a religious decision to a clinician.

Latin and Eastern Catholic differences matter, and this study does not project Latin law onto an Eastern Church. Catholics should seek the competent authority of their own Church; comparison does not license borrowed rites. The Catholic center remains Christological: evil is not God, Christ is victor, prayer is not magic, and the afflicted person remains neighbor.

13.4 The measure of a Christian response

The final measure is not how much attention a ministry gives the devil. It is whether the Church's action makes Christ's lordship credible through truth, freedom, mercy, prudence, and protection of the weak. An authorized major exorcism may be a real form of that care in a case judged according to the Church's discipline. Most readers will never encounter one. Every reader can refuse superstition, protect a suffering person, use ordinary prayer, receive the sacraments, seek competent help, and resist the glamour by which evil asks to become the center of the story.

This conclusion is deliberately less dramatic than the cultural image of the subject. It leaves unresolved what the evidence does not resolve and refuses to make a suffering person carry the burden of proving a worldview. It also refuses the opposite reduction by which the historical and theological claims of the Church are dismissed without being heard in their own terms. Sober Catholic practice requires neither credulity nor contempt. It requires confidence in Christ joined to truthful evidence, competent care, lawful authority, and patience with uncertainty.

Where this study leaves the reader

Do not attempt a rite, diagnosis, confrontation, or test. In immediate danger, contact the emergency or protective service appropriate to the jurisdiction. Do not change prescribed treatment on a minister's instruction; consult the treating clinician. For Catholic pastoral help, begin with a parish or the competent diocesan or eparchial authority; Orthodox Christians should begin with their canonical parish and bishop. Confidential, accountable care is not a failure of faith.

14 Scope, Method, and Historical Coordinates

14.1 Question, corpus, and periods

This study asks how diverse biblical, initiatory, pastoral, and ritual practices became the modern Latin Church's restricted major exorcism, and what the resulting history and current discipline do—and do not—authorize. Its selected corpus begins with Israelite and Second Temple contexts, moves through New Testament narratives, early Christian apology and initiation, late-antique offices and representative medieval Western books, and then follows the Roman Ritual, codification, twentieth-century reform, and current official sources. It is not an exhaustive catalog of rites, demonologies, local practice, or reported cases.

14.2 Place, Churches, language, and terminology

The historical account is principally Mediterranean and Western; its legal center is the Latin Church, with U.S. territorial implementation considered separately. A bounded comparison identifies why Latin law and ritual cannot be projected onto Eastern Catholic Churches; it does not state Orthodox law or practice. Ancient sources are read through the exact Greek, Latin, or identified English witnesses recorded in the source audit, including the Douay–Rheims/Challoner reception text, Robinson–Pierpont Byzantine Greek, Charles's English *Jubilees*, Whiston's

Josephus, and identified patristic and ritual editions. No Hebrew or Syriac wording supports a publication claim, and absence of an original-language collation is stated where material.

“Exorcism” is a family of historically changing uses, not the name of one unchanged ceremony. “Major exorcism” here means the solemn Latin liturgical act governed by canon 1172 and the applicable Roman ritual book. “Minor exorcism” refers chiefly to authorized initiatory prayers and never by itself implies possession. “Deliverance” creates neither a canonical category nor permission. Doctrine, school theology, historical witness, universal law, territorial implementation, clinical judgment, and project synthesis remain distinct.

14.3 Evidence classes, hierarchy, and method

Canonical narratives are read in their own literary and theological settings. Ancient and medieval texts establish what a witness says and how a practice was represented, not an event’s hidden cause or incidence. Official acts establish their own law, rite, publication, or guidance; they do not retrospectively authenticate a reported case. Modern scholarship assists reconstruction but does not supply ecclesiastical authority. Clinical classifications and safeguarding literature control claims within their professional scope, not theological judgments.

The method separates contemporary or near-contemporary evidence, later narrative and institutional memory, official reception, and modern reconstruction. It records textual and jurisdictional variation rather than silently harmonizing it. Named cases were excluded after a case-specific audit did not recover a sufficient chain of contemporary, official, medical, and reception evidence for the claims proposed.

14.4 Legal scope and currentness

The controlling universal law is the 1983 *Codex Iuris Canonici* for the Latin Church, promulgated by John Paul II, in its official Latin text, especially canon 1172. Pertinent dicastery acts and the current Roman ritual discipline are distinguished from the USCCB’s account of the English edition implemented for the Latin dioceses of the United States. The published authentic-interpretations register and material amendments were checked through 26 July 2026; no change to canon 1172 was located. Particular law and diocesan processes may add applicable controls and must be obtained from the competent authority. This work gives no opinion on an individual case.

14.5 Global uncertainties, rights, and review

No auditable global dataset establishes the frequency or outcomes of major exorcism. Ancient and medieval reports usually cannot be retrospectively diagnosed, and several early liturgical corpora have disputed dates, attributions, or compositional histories. The proprietary current ritual is neither reproduced nor operationally summarized. Protected modern works are quoted only in focused excerpts or paraphrased.

The repository’s CC BY 4.0 terms apply only to project-created synthesis, organization, and other contributions that the project may license. Scripture, liturgical and official texts, received translations, historical source wording, and modern scholarship retain their own status. The few biblical phrases quoted in the body use the identified public-domain Douay–Rheims/Challoner witness; ancient and medieval witnesses, official acts, modern scholarship, and clinical or safeguarding sources are otherwise paraphrased at identified loci. No scan, ritual formulary, modern-source table, diagnostic criteria, case transcript, recording, or third-party image is reproduced.

The historical-accounts profile governs the narrative. The articles profile applies only to bounded theological-authority and current-law claims. The expanded draft has received internal source, structural, and production review, including every-page visual inspection. Independent theological, canonical, patristic, historical-liturgical, clinical-safeguarding, pastoral, rights, and production review records dated 27 July 2026 govern their stated and deliberately bounded lanes. These reviews are not clinical validation, professional medical advice, or ecclesiastical approval. Exact-snapshot installation and distribution authorization remain separate gates.

This twenty-page snapshot is an interim public-alpha review paper. It does not fulfil the promised comprehensive study of at least 100 typeset pages; that expansion and its resulting source and specialist reviews remain open. Discoverability permits review and does not make this an official Church publication or an approved ritual, diagnostic, pastoral, or legal guide.

15 Dated Orientation

Ancient witnesses. *Jubilees* and Josephus preserve two unlike Second Temple or early Roman-period literary settings; their later English editions are evidence for the translations used here, not the dates of the underlying works. **First century.** Gospel and Acts narratives place expulsion of hostile spirits within Jesus’ kingdom ministry and apostolic mission. **Second–fourth centuries.** Apologetic and initiatory witnesses attest different Christian settings. Cornelius’s c. 251 Roman clergy list survives in fourth-century Eusebius; no unbound conciliar lead supplies a reader claim. **Early medieval witnesses.** The Gelasian Sacramentary survives through layered manuscripts; Wilson’s 1894 edition controls the passages used here. The tenth-century *Pontificale Romano-Germanicum* is identified bibliographically through the Vogel–Elze 1963–1972 edition; no exact ordo or page supports a publication claim here. **Thirteenth century.** Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* III, q. 71, distinguishes baptismal exorcistic acts within sacramental theology. **1614.** Paul V issues the *Rituale Romanum*; the princeps witness prints *De exorcizandis obsessis a daemonio* as one section at pp. 198–219. **1917–1918.** The first Latin Code is promulgated in 1917; the 1918 Vatican Polyglot book witness controls the canons cited here. **1952.** A later Roman Ritual edition arranges the material in title XII; it does not authorize present use by its historical existence. **1972.** *Ministeria quaedam* changes the Latin minor-order discipline.

1983. The revised Latin Code states the reservation and priestly qualifications in canon 1172. **29 September 1985.** The CDF restricts unauthorized use of exorcism formulas and direct interrogation in assemblies for liberation. **1998–2004.** A decree dated 22 November 1998 promulgates the revised book; the Latin typical edition appears in 1999, the dicastery presents it on 26 January 1999, and an emended reprint appears in 2004. **14 September 2000.** The CDF distinguishes exorcism from healing services and reaffirms dependence on the diocesan bishop. **2014–2017.** The USCCB approves the English edition in 2014, the Holy See confirms it in December 2016, and it takes effect in U.S. Latin dioceses on 29 June 2017. **22 October 2021.** The competent dicastery issues current implementation for amended canon 838, including the exorcism book’s preliminary norms. **26–27 July 2026.** The current-law check closes on 26 July; additional historical source acquisition and inspection is recorded on 27 July. The latter date does not silently extend the legal-currentness claim.

16 References by Source Function

16.1 Scripture and received teaching

Selected loci in 1 Samuel 16; Tobit 6–8; Matthew 4, 8, 12, 17; Mark 1, 3, 5, 9; Luke 4, 8, 10, 11, 13; Acts 16 and 19. Exact biblical editions and textual limits are recorded in the source audit. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 391–395, 550, 1237, 1667, 1670, 1673, 1700–1706, 1734–1735, 1857, 1859, 2111, 2116–2117, 2846–2854. Fourth Lateran Council, *Firmiter credimus*.

16.2 Ancient Jewish and Christian witnesses

Jubilees 10.1–11, trans. R. H. Charles (1913). Josephus, *Antiquities* 8.45–49, Whiston’s English. Justin Martyr, *Second Apology* 6, Dods–Reith English in *Ante-Nicene Fathers* 1 (1887), exact bounded OCR passage. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 1.10.1–3, Roberts–Rambaut English in the same volume, exact bounded OCR passage. Tertullian, *Apology* 23, Thelwall English. Origen, *Against Celsus* 1.6, 1.25, and 7.4, Crombie English. Jerusalem *Procatechesis* 9 and *Mystagogical Catechesis* 1.4–9, Gifford English. Eusebius, *Church History* 6.43.11, McGiffert English. The last five are exact dated New Advent delivery states acquired and hashed 2026-07-27.

16.3 Ritual and theological witnesses

Gelasian Sacramentary, selected scrutinies and exorcisms. *Pontificale Romano-Germanicum*, Vogel–Elze edition, catalog control only; exact ordines and pages remain an open research gate. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae*, first part, question 57, article 4; question 111, articles 2–4; question 114, articles 2–3; and third part, question 71, articles 2–4. *Rituale Romanum Pauli V* (1614), *De exorcizandis obsessis a daemonio*, printed pp. 198–219. *Rituale Romanum* (1952), title XII. Paul VI, *Ministeria quaedam* (1972).

16.4 Law and current official practice

Codex Iuris Canonici (1917), cc. 1151–1153; (1983), cc. 1166–1172. *Codex Canonum Ecclesiarum Orientalium* (1990), cc. 1–2. Congregation for the Doctrine of the Faith, letter to ordinaries concerning exorcism (29 September 1985), AAS 77 (1985), 1169–1170; and *Instruction on Prayers for Healing* (14 September 2000), art. 8. Congregation for Divine Worship and the Discipline of the Sacraments, *De Exorcismis et Supplicationibus Quibusdam*, promulgation decree (22 November 1998), 1999 typical edition, and 2004 emended reprint; official presentation (26 January 1999); decree implementing amended CIC canon 838 (22 October 2021). USCCB Secretariat of Divine Worship, “Exorcism,” accessed 26 July 2026.

16.5 Modern reconstruction and professional controls

Francis Young, *A History of Exorcism in Catholic Christianity* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2016), used critically as historical reconstruction. World Health Organization, *Clinical Descriptions and Diagnostic Requirements for ICD-11 Mental, Behavioural and Neurodevelopmental Disorders* (2024), used only within the bounded clinical discussion recorded in the source audit. United Kingdom Department for Education, *National action plan to tackle child abuse linked to faith or belief* (2012), used only for its England-specific safeguarding evidence.

17 Generation Metadata

Last revised (UTC): 2026-07-27T18:33:00Z

Model: GPT-5-based Codex agent; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agent (historical research, current-source verification, drafting, and source-audit roles); API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agent (multi-agent primary-source acquisition, historical and legal correction, safeguarding revision, component integration, source-library normalization, and production review); API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agent (public-alpha review labeling, promised-deliverable recovery, expansion planning, and publication-state reconciliation); API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

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